protest marches, vowing to fight the soldiers who would come to evict them. The court rejected Netanyahu's request.

Netanyahu fashions himself a man of big ideas, an intellectual concerned with the sweep of history. He likes to be photographed in the Knesset with a copy of *The Economist*, or Henry Kissinger's latest book. By mid-November, though, he was entirely consumed with the plight of forty families living illegally in trailers. "There is no one who is more concerned about settlement than us. Here as well, sagacity and responsibility are needed for the benefit of the settlements," he said at a cabinet meeting on 13 November.

With the deadline approaching, the cabinet drew up a number of "solutions" for Amona, many of them quite broad—aimed at legalizing not just Amona, but dozens of other outposts with thousands of residents. Ministers also discussed labeling the settlers a "protected population" a designation under international law that is applied to the inhabitants of occupied territory. Netanyahu, in a surreal twist, wanted to apply it to the occupiers themselves. On 16 November, a bill to legalize the outposts passed a first reading in the Knesset, by a vote of 58–50. Moshe Kahlon, the finance minister, had threatened to vote against it, but he dropped his opposition after the prime minister swore it would not harm the high court's reputation. Never mind, of course, that the bill was written specifically to undermine a ruling from that same court. The vote drew the requisite condemnations from the international community ("deeply concerned", in the words of John Kirby, the State Department spokesman). But it came at a fortuitous time for the Netanyahu government, days after Trump's election, while the West was preoccupied with the seeming demise of the liberal world order.

Then the attorney general piped up again, warning that any effort to authorize Amona would undermine the Supreme Court and the separation of powers. So in another bizarre twist, the language related to Amona was dropped from the bill. What began as an effort to keep forty families in their homes had metastasized into a law that "legalized" nearly 4,000 illegal residences—but the original forty would still be evicted.

The revised bill passed a first reading in the Knesset on 7 December, by a 60–49 vote. The lone dissenting vote from the coalition came from Benny Begin, the son of Menachem Begin, Israel's first Likud prime minister. It was a telling bit of symbolism. The elder Begin was a right-wing